

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1987-03-09

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 1987 in which you inquire about the role of the individual in interpretation
3 of the writings: specifically whether given the existence of interpretations by
4 the master and the guardian of passages from the writings, there remains
5 room for personal interpretations of these same texts. we are instructed to

convey the following points in reply.16.1

17 .1
18 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n
19 27The interpretations of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and the guardian are divinely guided
20 statements of what the word of god means and as such these interpreta-
21 tions are binding on the friends. however, the existence of authoritative
22 interpretations in no way precludes the individual from engaging in his own
23 study of the teachings and thereby arriving at his own interpretation or
understanding. indeed, bahá'u'lláh invites the believers to “immerse” them-
24 selves in the “ocean” of his “words,” that they “may unravel its secrets, and

discover all the pearls of wisdom that lie hid in its depths.”

25 17-1
26 far from knowledge being limited, bahá'u'lláh quotes the muslim tradi-
27 tion that “every knowledge hath seventy meanings,” and asserts that the
28 “meaning” of the word of god “can never be exhausted.”17-2 This potential
29 richness of meaning is underlined by the provision whereby future guard-
30 ians, while not abrogating the “interpretations of former guardians,” may
31 “elaborate and elucidate former interpretations,” as set out in the extract
32 from a letter dated 19 february 1947 which was written on behalf of Shoghi
33 effendi to an individual believer:

34 . . . regarding future guardians: they cannot “abrogate” the interpreta -
35 tions of former guardians, as this would imply not only lack of guidance

but mistakes in making them; however they can elaborate and elucidate

former interpretations, and can certainly abrogate some former ruling

36 laid down as a temporary necessity by a former guardian.

individual interpretations based on a person’s understanding of the

37 teachings constitute the fruit of man’s rational power and may well contrib-ute to a
more complete understanding of the faith. Such views, however,

38 lack authority. The believers are, therefore, free to accept or disregard them.

39 further, the manner in which an individual presents his interpretation

40 is important. for example, he must at no time deny or contend with the

41 authoritative interpretation, but rather offer his idea as a contribution to

42 knowledge, making it clear that his views are merely his own.

43 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

44 17-1. kA, ¶182.

45 17-2. ki, ¶283; gwb, no. 89.1.17 .2

17 .3

17 .3a

17 .4

18 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

19 2818

Avoiding Partisan Politics

and Promoting the Lesser Peace

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]